

FAMILY STUDIES

OVERVIEW

In the social sciences and humanities curriculum, family studies is a multidisciplinary subject area that encompasses four areas: fashion and housing; food and nutrition; general family studies; and raising and caring for children. The topics covered in these areas include, among others: textile production; the functions and design of clothing; the fashion industry; issues related to housing; interior design; the role of nutrition in health; the relationship between food and culture; human and family interactions and development; life management skills; various types of relationships; and considerations related to raising and caring for children.

In family studies courses, students learn about laws and policies that affect individuals and families in Canada and around the world. They also become familiar with the theoretical perspectives and practical research that underpin our understandings of individual and family development. Family studies courses also integrate theory and practical skills. Many expectations can be achieved through practical experiences both in the classroom and in co-op placements, some of which may be affiliated with Specialist High Skills Majors programs.

All courses in family studies encourage students to develop critical and creative thinking skills. Students are given opportunities to deepen their understanding of relevant issues and to develop practical skills, including research and inquiry skills. Students are encouraged to explore a range of perspectives and approaches and to develop the habits of mind that enhance individual, family, and community well-being and contribute to lifelong learning.

GENERAL FAMILY STUDIES

Human Development throughout the Lifespan, Grade 12

University/College Preparation

HHG4M

This course offers a multidisciplinary approach to the study of human development throughout the lifespan. Students will learn about a range of theoretical perspectives on human development. They will examine threats to healthy development as well as protective factors that promote resilience. Students will learn about physical, cognitive, and social-emotional development from the prenatal period through old age and will develop their research and inquiry skills by investigating issues related to human development.

Prerequisite: Any university, college, or university/college preparation course in social sciences and humanities, English, or Canadian and world studies

A. RESEARCH AND INQUIRY SKILLS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

Throughout this course, students will:

- A1. Exploring:** explore topics related to human development, and formulate questions to guide their research;
- A2. Investigating:** create research plans, and locate and select information relevant to their chosen topics, using appropriate social science research and inquiry methods;
- A3. Processing Information:** assess, record, analyse, and synthesize information gathered through research and inquiry;
- A4. Communicating and Reflecting:** communicate the results of their research and inquiry clearly and effectively, and reflect on and evaluate their research, inquiry, and communication skills.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

A1. Exploring

Throughout this course, students will:

- A1.1** explore a variety of topics related to human development (*e.g., brain development, effects of play on development, language development*) to identify topics for research and inquiry
- A1.2** identify key concepts (*e.g., through discussion, brainstorming, use of visual organizers*) related to their selected topics

- A1.3** formulate effective questions to guide their research and inquiry

Teacher prompt: “If you were studying the benefits to child development of participating in an early learning program, what might be the advantage of comparing experiences in early learning in different parts of the world or within diverse communities in the same area? Which aspects of these experiences would you compare? How would you ensure that your comparison was fair and valid?”

A2. Investigating

Throughout this course, students will:

- A2.1** create appropriate research plans to investigate their selected topics (*e.g., outline purpose and method; identify sources of information; develop*

research tools such as surveys or questionnaires), ensuring that their plans follow guidelines for ethical research

Teacher prompts: “What are some ways to locate reliable sources of information?” “For which purposes might websites such as Wikipedia be adequate sources of information? What are the risks of relying on websites such as Wikipedia?” “What methods would you use to ensure that you are following ethical guidelines when you develop surveys or interviews?”

- A2.2** locate and select information relevant to their investigations from a variety of primary sources (*e.g., interviews; observations; surveys and questionnaires; journal articles reporting on original research; original documents in print or other media such as film, photographs*) and secondary sources (*e.g., textbooks, literature reviews, bibliographies, encyclopedias*)

Teacher prompts: “What is the difference between primary and secondary sources in social sciences?” “Why is it important to base your research on a variety of secondary sources rather than just one or two?”

- A2.3** based on preliminary research, for each investigation formulate a hypothesis, thesis statement, or research question, and use it to focus their research

A3. Processing Information

Throughout this course, students will:

- A3.1** assess various aspects of information gathered from primary and secondary sources (e.g., accuracy, relevance, reliability, inherent values and bias, voice)

Teacher prompts: “What strategies can you use to determine the relevance of the information you have gathered?” “If two information sources contradict each other, how might you determine which is more reliable?” “What values are embedded in these sources?” “Whose voices are represented and whose are absent?” “Whose interests are advanced if you believe the main message of this source?”

- A3.2** record and organize information and key ideas using a variety of formats (e.g., notes, graphic organizers, summaries, audio/digital records)

- A3.3** analyse and interpret research information (e.g., compare information gathered from primary and secondary sources; determine whether similar information is found in different sources)

- A3.4** demonstrate academic honesty by documenting the sources of all information generated through research

- A3.5** synthesize findings and formulate conclusions (e.g., determine whether their results support or contradict their hypothesis; weigh and connect information to determine the answer to their research

questions; assess the extent to which their results may be affected by “confounding variables” – i.e., variables not controlled for in their research design)

A4. Communicating and Reflecting

Throughout this course, students will:

- A4.1** use an appropriate format (e.g., oral presentation, written research report, poster, multimedia presentation, web page) to communicate the results of their research and inquiry effectively for a specific purpose and audience

- A4.2** use terms relating to human development correctly (e.g., risk, resilience, protective factor, attachment, plasticity, identity, temperament)

- A4.3** clearly communicate the results of their inquiries (e.g., write clearly, organize ideas logically, use language conventions properly), and follow APA conventions for acknowledging sources (e.g., generate a reference list in APA style, use in-text author-date citations)

- A4.4** demonstrate an understanding of the general research process by reflecting on and evaluating their own research, inquiry, and communication skills

Teacher prompts: “How might the research methods you used have affected the results you obtained?” “What steps might you take to enhance your research/inquiry skills?”

B. DEVELOPMENTAL THEORIES, AND RISK AND RESILIENCE

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- B1. Theoretical Perspectives:** demonstrate an understanding of a variety of theoretical perspectives on human development;
- B2. Risk and Resilience:** demonstrate an understanding of threats to healthy development throughout the lifespan and of a variety of protective factors that can increase an individual's resilience and reduce the impact of these threats.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

B1. Theoretical Perspectives

By the end of this course, students will:

- B1.1** explain human development throughout the lifespan according to structuralist theoretical perspectives (*e.g., the stage theories of Sigmund Freud, Erik Erikson, Jean Piaget*)

Teacher prompt: "According to structuralist theories, does development occur primarily in response to internal or external factors?"

- B1.2** explain human development throughout the lifespan according to information-processing and learning theoretical perspectives (*e.g., the theories of Ivan Pavlov, B. F. Skinner, John B. Watson, Albert Bandura*)

Teacher prompt: "According to learning theorists, what is the main driver of development?"

- B1.3** explain human development throughout the lifespan according to systemic and humanistic theoretical perspectives (*e.g., the theories of Urie Bronfenbrenner, Abraham Maslow, Carl Rogers, Bonnie Burstow, Barbara Rogoff*)

Teacher prompt: "Why would humanistic or systemic theorists think that it is important to consider the ways in which government policies support or inhibit child development?"

B2. Risk and Resilience

By the end of this course, students will:

- B2.1** describe threats to healthy development and their impact at various stages of life (*e.g., poverty, discrimination, political unrest, environmental*

degradation, physical and mental illness, substance abuse, physical/sexual abuse)

Teacher prompts: "How might early childhood development be affected by political unrest and war?" "How and why might the impact of poverty on the development of young children be different from its impact on the development of elderly people?"

- B2.2** explain how protective factors at the individual, familial, and community levels (*e.g., intelligence; strong relationships with one or more adults; exposure to enriched learning environments; community supports such as Meals on Wheels, senior centres, literacy centres*) can promote resilience in individuals

- B2.3** describe ways in which government policies and initiatives by non-governmental organizations (NGOs) at the local and global levels can function as protective factors that reduce the impact of threats to human development at different stages of the lifespan (*e.g., government policies supporting full-day Kindergarten, parental leave, and preventive health care; establishing green space; combating global climate change; NGO initiatives such as the Stephen Lewis Foundation's support for grandmothers raising grandchildren orphaned by AIDS or Planned Parenthood's maternal health programs*)

- B2.4** describe opportunities for involvement in local community initiatives that address challenges to human development (*e.g., school-wide fundraising for organizations providing support to children and families; food drives; volunteer opportunities with literacy initiatives, in Big Brothers/Big Sisters, at retirement homes*)

C. UNDERSTANDING PHYSICAL DEVELOPMENT

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- C1. Physical Development and Brain Physiology:** demonstrate an understanding of physical development, including brain physiology and development, throughout the lifespan;
- C2. Sensory and Motor Development:** demonstrate an understanding of sensory and motor development at different stages of the lifespan;
- C3. Factors Affecting Physical Development:** demonstrate an understanding of contextual factors that can affect physical development, particularly brain development, throughout the lifespan and of the effects of these factors.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

C1. Physical Development and Brain Physiology

By the end of this course, students will:

- C1.1** explain theories of human physical development (*e.g., the theories of Arnold Gesell, Esther Thelen*)
Teacher prompt: “According to Gesell, why do children develop the ability to reach before they develop the ability to print?”
- C1.2** describe the major changes in the body throughout the lifespan (*e.g., cephalocaudal and proximodistal patterns of growth in infancy and childhood; changes associated with puberty; changes related to sex drive, sexual attraction, and reproduction; changes associated with menopause; physical changes in elderly people*)
- C1.3** describe human brain physiology, including key structures and their functions (*e.g., the brain-stem is responsible for basic vital life functions such as breathing; the cerebellum is responsible for movement, posture, and balance*)
- C1.4** describe the development of the brain from the prenatal period through the elder years, with particular emphasis on significant changes that occur throughout the lifespan (*e.g., neuron formation, neural tube development, neurogenesis, neuronal migration, myelination, synaptogenesis,*

development of the prefrontal cortex, peak periods of growth for each brain lobe, synaptic pruning, brain shrinkage, slowing of brain function)

C2. Sensory and Motor Development

By the end of this course, students will:

- C2.1** analyse the major milestones in motor skills development in the early years of life (*e.g., milestones related to reflexes, gross motor skills, fine motor skills*)
Teacher prompts: “How do the rooting reflex, sucking reflex, and moro reflex of early infancy help to ensure survival?” “Most children develop the pincer grasp at approximately seven months of age. To what extent does this development depend on their experience manipulating objects?” “At what age do most children learn to crawl, walk, and run?”
- C2.2** describe changes to sensory faculties and motor skills in later life (*e.g., presbyopia, presbycusis, decline in taste buds, reduced muscle strength and bone density, slower reflexes*), and explain strategies that can be used to slow, prevent, or otherwise address their decline (*e.g., doing regular cardiovascular and weight-bearing exercise, practising good nutrition, wearing ear protection when working around loud noises, having cataract surgery, wearing a hearing aid*)

C3. Factors Affecting Physical Development

By the end of this course, students will:

C3.1 explain how various factors affect physical development throughout the lifespan (*e.g., illness, injury, genetic factors, nutrition, exercise*)

C3.2 analyse the long-term effects of early environmental stimulation and deprivation on brain development (*e.g., stimulation produces a heavier brain with thicker layers, more neural connections, and greater neurochemical activity; deprivation hinders brain activity*)

Teacher prompts: “How does early stimulation affect brain functioning?” “How does nutrition affect brain development and functioning?” “How does childhood play stimulate the brain? Why is such stimulation important? How does play in childhood protect the brain from degeneration in later adulthood?”

C3.3 identify factors that can affect brain development during the prenatal period (*e.g., maternal and paternal illness; maternal stress, substance abuse, or nutritional deficiencies; advanced maternal or paternal age; teratogens; some prescription drugs; environmental pollutants; infectious diseases*), and analyse their impact

Teacher prompt: “If you were a family physician, what advice would you give to your patients who were preparing to conceive? What advice would you give if one of your patients was worried about having smoked before she knew she was pregnant?”

C3.4 describe brain plasticity with reference to the brain’s response to injury, illness, and environmental factors (*e.g., physical injuries, strokes, aphasia, stress, substance abuse, infectious diseases, environmental toxins, nutritional deficiencies*)

Teacher prompt: “After a stroke, how does the plasticity of the brain allow recovery of some functioning that had initially been lost?”

D. COGNITIVE DEVELOPMENT, LANGUAGE DEVELOPMENT, AND INTELLIGENCE

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- D1. Cognitive Development:** demonstrate an understanding of theories of cognitive development and of changes in aspects of cognitive development throughout the lifespan;
- D2. Language Acquisition and Development:** explain the processes and physiological foundations of language acquisition and development throughout the lifespan;
- D3. Intelligence:** demonstrate an understanding of issues related to defining, measuring, and developing intelligence;
- D4. Factors Affecting Cognitive Development and Language Use:** analyse the effects of contextual factors on cognitive development and language use throughout the lifespan.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

D1. Cognitive Development

By the end of this course, students will:

- D1.1** explain theories of human cognitive development (*e.g., the theories of Jean Piaget, Lev Vygotsky, Noam Chomsky, Maria Montessori, Robert J. Sternberg*)

Teacher prompt: “According to Vygotsky, what is the best way to promote cognitive development of young children?”

- D1.2** explain theories of moral development (*e.g., the theories of Lawrence Kohlberg, Carol Gilligan, Moshe Blatt, James Rest*)

Teacher prompt: “According to Kohlberg, what are the connections between cognitive and moral development?”

- D1.3** describe cognitive development throughout the lifespan (*e.g., the development of theory of mind in preschoolers, dualistic thinking of adolescents, reflective thinking of adults, wisdom in later adulthood*)

Teacher prompt: “What is wisdom? What types of life experiences and cognitive capacity would be required to develop wisdom? Is it possible for a young adult to show wisdom? Why or why not?”

- D1.4** explain how information processing changes throughout the lifespan (*e.g., with reference to short- and long-term memory, critical thinking, problem solving, decision making*), with emphasis on changes in attention, memory, thinking, and metacognition

Teacher prompts: “What is the impact of attention on storage and retrieval of information?”
“In what ways do children and adults differ in the problem-solving strategies they use?”

D2. Language Acquisition and Development

By the end of this course, students will:

- D2.1** explain the physiological foundations of language development (*e.g., the areas of the brain related to language processing*)

Teacher prompt: “What role do Broca’s area and Wernicke’s area play in language development?”

- D2.2** explain the processes of language acquisition and development throughout the lifespan

Teacher prompts: “How does verbal and non-verbal stimulation enhance or impede language development?” “Why is it easier for people to learn a new language when they are young

rather than middle-aged?” “What have researchers found about the connection between knowing multiple languages and the onset of dementia in old age?”

D3. Intelligence

By the end of this course, students will:

D3.1 analyse various aspects of intelligence (*e.g., infant intelligence, multiple intelligences, social intelligence, emotional intelligence, fluid and crystallized intelligence*)

Teacher prompt: “In what ways do cultures differ in their valuing of different aspects of intelligence (*e.g., spatial skills in societies that engage in hunting and trapping; linguistic and mathematical skills in Western societies*)?”

D3.2 explain the limitations of standardized tests of intelligence (*e.g., lack of “culture-fair” tests; reliance on language as the basis for testing; stereotype threat*)

D3.3 analyse current research on the impact of environment on intelligence (*e.g., the Fraser Mustard report, the Charles Pascal report*)

Teacher prompts: “What does research reveal about the impact of environmental stimulation on intelligence?” “Intelligence research is

generally based on correlational rather than experimental data. What are the challenges in interpreting correlational data?”

D4. Factors Affecting Cognitive Development and Language Use

By the end of this course, students will:

D4.1 explain the effects of individual differences (*e.g., differences related to giftedness, developmental delays, attention deficit disorder, autism, school anxiety, aphasia, depression, schizophrenia, dementia, Alzheimer’s, birth order, gender*) on cognitive development throughout the lifespan

Teacher prompt: “What have researchers found about the differences in cognitive development of first-borns in comparison to later-born children?”

D4.2 evaluate the effects of rapidly changing technology on cognitive development and language use throughout the lifespan (*e.g., the effects of increased use of texting language, the effects on cognitive processing speed*)

Teacher prompt: “What cognitive advantages and disadvantages would today’s youth, who rely heavily on communications technology, have when compared to people who were young thirty years ago?”

E. SOCIAL-EMOTIONAL DEVELOPMENT AND PERSONALITY

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- E1. Social-Emotional Development:** demonstrate an understanding of social-emotional development throughout the lifespan and of ways of influencing such development;
- E2. Personality and Identity:** demonstrate an understanding of various influences on personality development and identity formation throughout the lifespan;
- E3. Factors Affecting Social-Emotional Development:** demonstrate an understanding of how factors affect social-emotional development, with an emphasis on the process of socialization.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

E1. Social-Emotional Development

By the end of this course, students will:

- E1.1** explain attachment theory as it relates to human development (*e.g., with reference to the theories of John Bowlby, Mary Ainsworth, Kim Bartholomew*)
Teacher prompts: “According to attachment theorists, why is infant attachment important?”
- E1.2** describe the development of emotion throughout the lifespan (*e.g., early emotions, stranger anxiety, emotional fluctuations, socio-emotional selectivity*)
Teacher prompts: “What are the first emotions that infants show?” “What differences might there be in the ways in which a teenage girl and an elderly woman express anger? What would account for these differences?”
- E1.3** describe ways in which parents and caregivers can promote secure attachment in infants and children (*e.g., nurturing, responsive care, breastfeeding*)
- E1.4** explain the effects that secure and insecure attachment in the early years can have on social-emotional development in adolescence and adulthood

Teacher prompts: “How does secure attachment in early life affect relationship building in later life?” “What types of behaviour and attitudes are characteristic of adults who have an anxious attachment style?”

E2. Personality and Identity

By the end of this course, students will:

- E2.1** explain the process of identity formation throughout the lifespan (*e.g., with reference to gender identity, ethnic identity, identity statuses*)
Teacher prompts: “How can families encourage the development of bicultural identity among its members?” “What circumstances can prompt role confusion in adolescence?” “What causes adults to go through identity reformulation?”
- E2.2** explain how birth order and temperament can affect the development of an individual’s personality
Teacher prompts: “In what ways can sibling rivalry affect self-concept and the development of personality?” “What are the common personality traits of children who had an easy temperament in infancy? Of those who had a difficult temperament?”

E2.3 analyse the relationship between personality and social interactions (e.g., the differences that introverted and extraverted people might experience in their social interactions; the impact on one's personality of nurturing, supportive, empathetic interactions and critical, controlling ones)

Teacher prompts: "How might being in an abusive relationship affect an individual's personality?" "In what ways might being a high achiever affect an individual's interactions with colleagues or friends?"

E3. Factors Affecting Social-Emotional Development

By the end of this course, students will:

E3.1 analyse the role that family plays in socializing its members (e.g., with reference to the development of language, communication skills, confidence, competence, and self-esteem, and to the transmission of gender roles, culture, religion, and values such as respect for elders and for the environment)

E3.2 analyse the effects of socialization on the social-emotional functioning of individuals throughout the lifespan (e.g., with respect to individuals' values, behaviour, and sense of social responsibility; their ability to adjust to change,

balance work and leisure, engage and communicate with other people and maintain relationships; their response to peer pressure, discrimination; the relationship between poor socialization and defiance, delinquency, and disengagement)

Teacher prompts: "What have been some of the long-term effects of residential schools on the social-emotional functioning of First Nation children?" "What are some of the effects of isolation on the elderly?" "What trends have researchers found in the social-emotional functioning of adult men and women who grew up in homes where they witnessed their father batter their mother?"

E3.3 assess the impact of marginalization (e.g., marginalization related to factors such as age, poverty, disability, gender, sexual orientation, ethnicity, religion, low literacy levels) on social-emotional development

Teacher prompts: "How does the marginalization of people with disabilities leave them at higher risk for exploitation or victimization?" "Why do some societies disregard the skills, knowledge, and experiences of the elderly? What impact can this have on older people?" "What are the social-emotional benefits of a companion animal or animal-assisted therapy for elderly or disabled people?"